The University of Alberta respectfully acknowledges that we are located on Treaty 6 territory, a traditional gathering place for diverse Indigenous peoples including the Cree, Blackfoot, Metis, Nakota Sioux, Iroquois, Dene, Ojibway/Saulteaux/Anishinaabe and Inuit.

ENGL 102 B15 Introduction to Critical Analysis (*3), Winter 2026
Instructor: Meaghan Sych

Lectures: Monday, Wednesday, Friday 2:00-2:50pm
Location: Tory 1-105

Instructor office hours
Office: Humanities Centre 3-5
Office Hours: Wednesdays 11-1:00 or by appointment
Email: mesych@ualberta.ca

I normally respond to emails within a day; at busy times of the term I may take a bit longer. Please note that I don't normally respond to email in the evenings or on the weekends or holidays. Although I sometimes end up doing class preparation or marking at these times, I am not actually "at" work and not normally checking email. For this reason, it's important, when you need to request an extension for an assignment or have a question about course work, to get it to me in reasonable time for me to respond.

Learning management system
I will be using Canvas for this course. Grades will also be available there. Slides will not be provided to students on Canvas, please get notes from other students if you have to miss class.

Course objectives
How does critical analysis matter to reading and understanding literature, broadly conceived? In this course, we will explore methods of critical analysis through a wide range of texts from different historical periods and cultural locations. In studying language, literature, and culture, students may encounter a diversity of print texts and other media. Students will also develop their abilities to communicate original, evidence-based interpretations of texts in a variety of forms, including writing and oral discussions.

ENGL 102 D01 introduces students to the study of literature and cultural texts at the postsecondary level and to the methods of critical reading and analysis that are central to this area of study. We have four main objectives in this class:

• to introduce students to the study of English at the post-secondary level
• to develop students' skills in critical reading and analysis of literary and cultural texts across a range of genres
• to develop students' skills in writing at the university level

• to familiarize students with the practices of quoting and citing materials used in formal assignments (MLA style will be used for formatting assignments and for citation in this class)

Before completing registration, students should be sure to check the regulations of their faculties. Requirements vary throughout the University, and final questions about programs rest with faculty offices. Inquiries about the junior English program and individual junior courses may be addressed to the Department of English and Film Studies First-Year Teaching Coordinator, Dr. Kristine Smitka (smitka@ualberta.ca). All students wanting to take senior English courses must first successfully complete 6 credits at the junior level consisting of two 3-credit junior English courses *or* one 3-credit junior English course and WRS 101. No more than 6 credits of English at the 100 level will be accepted for credit in any program.

Required texts

- Tommy Orange, *There There* (book may be purchased at the University of Alberta Bookstore; ebooks are fine, but you *must* have a copy of the text to read and discuss)
- all other course readings are online and are linked in the syllabus/on Canvas

Be sure to check all required readings for each week. The best preparation is to read required readings ahead of the first class in which the text will be discussed. Please bring a copy of all texts – on your device or on paper – to all classes. Laptops or other electronic devices are not required in class, but please **be sure to always have a copy of the day's readings on paper if you don't bring a device**. It's hard to engage with a conversation about a text if you don't have it in front of you. Please always bring paper and a writing device to class, for note-taking, quizzes and in-class work. Most assignments will be completed in class and require writing by hand.

Recording of Lectures

Audio or video recording, digital or otherwise, of lectures, labs, seminars or any other teaching environment by students is allowed only with the prior written consent of the instructor or as a part of an approved accommodation plan. Student or instructor content, digital or otherwise, created and/or used within the context of the course is to be used solely for personal study, and is not to be used or distributed for any other purpose without prior written consent from the content author(s).

Grading

Students will receive a letter and number grade on assignments. The Faculty of Arts expects that the average of the average course grades for all the undergraduate courses offered by each department at each level will fall in the specified range for that course level. Grade approvers in the Department of English and Film Studies have the authority to require instructors to make changes to the unofficial grades. Student grades are unofficial until they have been approved by Arts Faculty Council or delegate.

Rubrics will be used where relevant, and are outlined below. Most assignments will be completed in class and require writing by hand.

Grade Scale in the Department of English and Film Studies

Excellent	A+	4.0	96-100
	A	4.0	91–95
	A-	3.7	86–90
Good	B+	3.3	81–85
	B	3.0	76–80
	B-	2.7	72–75
Satisfactory	C+	2.3	68–71
	C	2.0	63–67
	C-	1.7	59–62
Poor	D+	1.3	55–58
Minimal Pass	D	1.0	50–54
Fail	F	0.0	0–49

Distribution of grades:

- **Participation (see information below) (10%)**
- **In-class writing Wednesday, January 28: assemble a 5-step paragraph (5%)**
- **Quiz Friday, January 30: 5 multiple-choice questions on the U of A MLA citation tutorial (5%)**
- **In-class writing Friday, February 13: respond to a question on the documentary *Sugarcane*; your answer must demonstrate your understanding of the 5-step structure and must be at least 5 (complete and grammatical!) sentences in length. (10%)**
  rubric (A+-F): choice of image, description, explanation, clarity of writing, demonstration of engagement with the documentary
- **Quiz Friday, February 27: five multiple-choice questions on *The Archive Project* episode (5%)**
- **In-class writing Friday, March 6: integrating quotations, using signal phrases (5%)**

- **Quiz Friday, March 13: 10 multiple-choice questions on *There There* (10%)**
- **In-class writing Friday, March 20: 5-step paragraph on *There There* (10%)**
  rubric (A+-F): effective topic sentence, clearly follows structure of 5-step paragraph, evidence provided, clear and effective writing, effective engagement with text
- **Revised *Sugarcane* or *There There* assignment due Wednesday, April 1 (10%)**
  This is an assignment to do at home, on a computer. Transcribe the paragraph you wrote in class on *Sugarcane* or the one you wrote in class on *There There* making the following adjustments:
  *** format the assignment correctly in MLA style**
  *** change the sentences as needed to ensure that the paragraph follows the structure of the 5-step paragraph**
  *** introduce at least one quotation, using a signal phrase and an in-text citation, correctly formatted**
  *** include a correctly formatted Works Cited**
  Please also indicate at the end of the assignment (following the Works Cited) what changes you made. Submit the assignment as a printed document*, with the original in-class paragraph attached*.
  rubric (A+-F): formatting, quotation and signal phrase, indication of changes made, alignment with 5-step paragraph guidelines, clear and correct writing
- **Final examination 2 hours, Tentative date: Monday, April 20, Location TBA 30%**

Attendance and Participation
Regular attendance is essential for optimal performance in any course. The University of Alberta Calendar makes this note:

> Since presence at lectures, participation in classroom discussions and projects, and the completion of assignments are important components of most courses, students will serve their interests best by regular attendance. Those who choose not to attend must assume whatever risks are involved.

Participation accounts for 10% of your grade in ENGL 102. Participation in a class generally includes the following:

- engagement in class discussions,
- attention to lectures and presentations by instructors or fellow students,
- demonstration of preparation for class (being familiar with course texts, being ready to talk about them, having a copy of the day's texts with you),
- participating in class discussions,
- asking and answering questions,
- not spending time on computers or phones if not doing work for this class during this class,
- not chattering or interfering with other students' ability to follow class discussions,

- not using headphones in class,
- not snoozing during class.

Participation in this class also includes the following:

- attending your instructor's office hours *at least once* during the term,
- contacting your instructor by email *at least once* during the term,
- handing in coursework on time and with regard to the instructions provided.

Policy for Late Assignments

Late assignments will lose .5 of a letter grade per day. Extensions MUST be requested and approved by email or in person no less than 24 hours (one full day) ahead of the due date for the assignment.

Missed Tests and Assignments

Receiving alternate arrangements for the completion of term work is a privilege and not a right. There is no guarantee that late work will be accepted or that an absence will be excused. Misrepresentation of facts to gain an unfair academic advantage over other students is a violation of section 5.a in the *Student Academic Integrity Policy*.

The University of Alberta is committed to the highest standards of academic integrity and honesty. Students are expected to be familiar with these standards regarding academic honesty and to uphold the policies of the University in this respect. Students are particularly urged to familiarize themselves with the provisions of the Student Academic Integrity Policy and the Student Conduct Policy (on the University of Alberta Policies and Procedures Online (UAPPOL) website) and avoid any behaviour which could potentially result in suspicions of cheating, plagiarism, misrepresentation of facts and/or participation in an offence. Academic dishonesty is a serious offence and can result in suspension or expulsion from the University.

AI

Instructors at the University of Alberta are asked to be clear about the use of AI permitted in a course. In ENGL 102 B15, students may use AI where it is permitted for assignments, noting that the use of AI for any assignment requires clear indication and citation of the AI as well as of at least one source used to check the accuracy of AI-provided information.

Schedule of classes, readings and assignments

Week of Jan. 5-9

Intros, writing exercises

Intro to course, readings, assignments, grades
Keywords: critical, analysis, genre, close reading, poetry, lyric, speaker
Readings: Robert Frost, "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening"; A.E. Houseman, "Loveliest of trees, the cherry now"

Week of Jan. 12-16
Keywords: reading poetry continued, critical, analysis, genre, close reading, poetry, lyric, speaker, figurative language, subject; introduction to 5-step paragraphs, topic sentence, controlling idea
Readings: Lillian Allen, "I saw a perfect tree today"; Adam Dickinson, "Hail"; Emily Dickinson, "I'm Nobody! Who are you?"; "Paragraphs," UNCCH Writing Centre

Week of Jan. 19-23
Keywords: critical analysis; context, text, situated close reading, necessary contextual information: what the poem/text tells us it needs in order to be read; 5-step paragraphs continued
Readings: Derek Walcott, "Ruins of a Great House"**;** "Paragraph Development in 5 Steps," Cuyamaca College

Week of Jan. 26-30
Keywords: situated close reading continued; necessary contextual information continued; researching context; 5-step paragraphs continued; introduction to citation, in-text citation; parenthetical citation; MLA style, Works Cited
Readings: Langston Hughes, "Harlem"; Claude McKay, "The Tropics in New York"; MLA citation tutorial (U of A Library)
In-class writing Wednesday, January 28: assemble a 5-step paragraph (5%)
Quiz Friday, January 30: 5 multiple-choice questions on the U of A MLA citation tutorial (5%)

Week of Feb. 2-6
Keywords: context, situated or contextual reading, Indigenous literatures, mindful reading, colonization, decolonization, settler colonialism, reconciliation, TRC; citation, MLA style, Works Cited
Readings: Daniel Heath Justice, "Introduction: Stories that Wound, Stories that Heal," *Why Indigenous Literatures Matter* (2018), pp. 19-43; sections from the TRC Calls to Action
(Note that you must be signed in to the U of A Library using either your CCID and password or your library barcode; if this link does not work, you can find the ebook in the library catalogue and can navigate to the introduction, which you can download or read online.)

Week of Feb. 9-13

Keywords: residential schools, image, mindful reading, documentary, intergenerational trauma
Readings:; *Sugarcane* (documentary), dir. Julian Brave NoiseCat, Emily Kassie, https://ualberta.aviaryplatform.com/collections/1785/collection_resources/148190
(Note that you must be signed in to the U of A Library using either your CCID and password or your library barcode; if this link does not work, you can find the film in the library catalogue and can view it online)
In-class writing Friday, February 13: respond to a question on the documentary *Sugarcane*; your answer must demonstrate your understanding of the 5-step structure and must be at least 5 (complete and grammatical!) sentences in length. (10%)
rubric (A+-F): choice of image, description, explanation, clarity of writing, demonstration of engagement with the documentary

Week of Feb. 16-20
Reading week: no classes

Week of Feb. 23-27
Keywords: novel, analyzing novels, narrative, narrator, narrative voices, polyphonic, plot, epigraph, character, setting; introduction to integrating quotations; signal phrases; signal verbs
Readings: Tommy Orange, *There There* (Prologue and Part I, "Remain")
The Archive Project podcast, interview with Tommy Orange (2019)
Quiz Friday, February 27: five multiple-choice questions on *The Archive Project* episode (5%)

Week of Mar. 2-6
Keywords: integrating quotations; signal phrases; signal verbs, continued
Readings: Tommy Orange, *There There* (Part II, "Reclaim")
In-class writing Friday, March 6: integrating quotations, using signal phrases (5%)

Week of Mar. 9-13
Keywords: review: 5-step paragraphs, integrating quotations, citation, formatting an assignment, Works Cited
Readings: Tommy Orange, *There There* (Part III, "Return," and Part IV, "Powwow"); sections of the Purdue OWL (through the University of Alberta Library) on the Works Cited page and the format of an assignment LINK and **LINK**
Quiz Friday, March 13: 10 multiple-choice questions on *There There* (10%)

Week of Mar. 16-20
Keywords: narrative, other forms: shorter than a novel; integrating quotations continued
Readings: Colson Whitehead, "The Match" (note that you must be signed in to the U of A Library using either your CCID and password or your library barcode; if this link does not work,

you can find *The New Yorker* in the library catalogue and can navigate to the story, which was published in the magazine on March 25, 2019)
In-class writing Friday, March 20: 5-step paragraph on *There There* (10%)
rubric (A+-F): effective topic sentence, clearly follows structure of 5-step paragraph, evidence provided, clear and effective writing, effective engagement with text

Week of Mar. 23-27
Keywords: narrative, other forms: shorter than a novel continued
Readings: Colson Whitehead, "The Match"
narrative, short story, epiphany, how short stories work; paragraph, topic sentence, evidence, title; integrating quotations, signal phrases continued; formatting an assignment

Week of Mar. 30-Apr. 3
University closed Apr. 3
Keywords: narrative, short story, epiphany, how short stories work; paragraph, topic sentence, evidence, title; integrating quotations, signal phrases continued; formatting an assignment
Revised *Sugarcane* or *There There* assignment due Wednesday, April 1 (10%)
This is an assignment to do at home, on a computer. Transcribe the paragraph you wrote in class on *Sugarcane* or the one you wrote in class on *There There* making the following adjustments:
* format the assignment correctly in MLA style
* change the sentences as needed to ensure that the paragraph follows the structure of the 5-step paragraph
* introduce at least one quotation, using a signal phrase and an in-text citation, correctly formatted
* include a correctly formatted Works Cited
Please also indicate at the end of the assignment (following the Works Cited) what changes you made. Submit the assignment as a printed document*, with the original in-class paragraph attached*.
rubric (A+-F): formatting, quotation and signal phrase, indication of changes made, alignment with 5-step paragraph guidelines, clear and correct writing

Week of Apr. 6-10
University closed Apr. 6
Keywords: exam outline, preparation; catching up

Final exam: 30%, date and location TBA
See exam planner.

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Learning and Working Environment
The Faculty of Arts is committed to ensuring that all students, faculty and staff are able to work and study in an environment that is safe and free from discrimination and harassment. It does not tolerate behaviour that undermines that environment.

All students should review the *Student Conduct Policy* (on the University of Alberta Policies and Procedures Online [UAPPOL] website). If you are experiencing harassment, discrimination, fraud, theft or any other issue and would like confidential advice and information, please contact any of these campus services:

- Office of Safe Disclosure & Human Rights*:* A safe, neutral and confidential space to disclose concerns about how the University of Alberta policies, procedures or ethical standards are being applied. They provide strategic advice and referral on matters such as discrimination, harassment, duty to accommodate and wrong-doings. Disclosures can be made in person or online using the Online Reporting Tool

- Sexual Violence Supports: It is the policy of the University of Alberta that sexual violence committed by any member of the University community is prohibited and constitutes misconduct. The University takes seriously its responsibility to reduce sexual and gender-based violence through a culture of consent, gender inclusivity, anti-oppression and support, and to respond to misconduct or conditions that allow, facilitate, or give rise to sexual and gender-based violence.

- University of Alberta Protective Services: Peace officers dedicated to ensuring the safety and security of U of A campuses and community. Staff or students can contact UAPS to make a report if they feel unsafe, threatened, or targeted on campus or by another member of the university community. For non-emergency dispatch, call 780-492-5050. For lost and found, call 780-492-2943. In an emergency, call 911.

Student Resources
The University Calendar is one of the principal sources of U of A policy information for students. It includes admission requirements and deadlines, academic regulations, programs of study, academic standards, degree requirements, and University policies for both undergraduate and graduate students.

The Student Service Centre provides students with information and access to services to support academic, financial, mental, and physical well-being.

First Peoples' House provides an environment of empowerment for First Nations, Métis, and Inuit learners to achieve personal and academic growth.

The Academic Success Centre provides professional academic support to help students maximize their academic success and achieve their academic goals. They offer appointments, advising, group workshops, online courses, and specialized programming year-round to students in all university programs, and at all levels of achievement and study.

Writing Services offers free one-on-one writing support to students, faculty, and staff. Students can request a consultation for a writing project at any stage of development. Instructors can request class visits and presentations.

Under the Discrimination, Harassment and Duty to Accommodate Policy, the Office of the Dean of Students coordinates academic accommodations for prospective and current students with documented disabilities affecting mobility, vision, hearing, learning, and physical or mental health. The provision of academic accommodations helps to remove structural barriers that these students encounter in academic environments in order to facilitate equivalent learning opportunities for these students. Accommodations and Accessibility promotes an accessible, inclusive, and universally-designed environment at the University of Alberta.

Health and Wellness Support for Students outlines the mental and physical health resources which are offered on-campus and in the community.

The Office of the Student Ombuds is a confidential service which strives to ensure that university processes related to students operate as fairly as possible. They offer information, advice, and support to students, faculty, and staff as they deal with academic, discipline, interpersonal, and financial issues related to student programs.

The Campus Food Bank is an independent charity supporting University of Alberta students, faculty, staff, and alumni; it is located in SUB 1-81.

The UofA's Student Union lists opportunities, including job postings, volunteer opportunities, and scholarships, grants, and other awards.

The Need Help Now webpage offers contact information for a variety of supports if you are in immediate need of mental health and wellness support. You can also call the 24-hour Distress Line: 780-482-4357 (HELP).

MAP of gender-neutral washrooms HERE. Please note there are also gender-neutral washrooms on the third floor of the Humanities Centre by the West elevator.

Policy about course outlines can be found in Course Requirements, Evaluation Procedures and Grading in the University Calendar.

Syllabus checklist, FYI

a. a statement of the course objectives and general content
b. a list of the required textbooks and other major course materials
c. a list of any other course fees as described in the 'Student Instructional Support Fees Policy' and their associated costs
d. an indication of how and when students have access to the instructor
e. the distribution of weight between term work and final examination
f. the relative weight of all term work contributing to the course grade
g. whether marks are given for class participation and other in-class activities as well as the weight of such participation
h. dates of any examination and course assignments with a weight of 10% or more of the overall course grade
i. the process by which the term marks will be translated into a final letter grade for the course. The process must be consistent with the University of Alberta Assessment Policy and accompanying Grading Procedure, found at the University of Alberta Policies and Principles Online (UAPPOL) website.
j. an indication of how students will be given access to past or representative evaluative course material, consistent with the Access to Evaluative Material Procedure of the Assessment Policy, found at the University of Alberta Policies and Procedures Online (UAPPOL) website.
k. the statement: "Policy about course outlines can be found in Course Requirements, Evaluation Procedures and Grading in the University Calendar."
l. the statement: "The University of Alberta is committed to the highest standards of academic integrity and honesty. Students are expected to be familiar with these standards regarding academic honesty and to uphold the policies of the University in this respect. Students are particularly urged to familiarize themselves with the provisions of the Student Academic Integrity Policy and the Student Conduct Policy (on the University of Alberta Policies and Procedures Online (UAPPOL) website) and avoid any behaviour which could potentially result in suspicions of cheating, plagiarism, misrepresentation of facts and/or participation in an offence. Academic dishonesty is a serious offence and can result in suspension or expulsion from the University."